VILLAINS OF THE PIECE

THE MAJOR RISK FACTORS THAT CONTRIBUTE TO HEART DISEASE



DIET HIGH IN SALT, SUGAR AND FAT

According to studies, an average urban Indian consumes 11 gm salt a day against the WHO recommended 6 gm (per George Institute for Global Health, India), 10 spoons of sugar against the recommended 6 and 32.6 gm of fat against the 20 gm recommendation (study by ICMR). Overconsumption of sugar, salt and fat cause diseases that damage the heart



STRESS

It can directly impact the heart through the release of inflammatory hormones or indirectly lead people to make poor dietary and lifestyle choices. A 2020 study by the Centre of Healing of 10,000 Indians said 74% suffered from stress and anxiety

POOR PREVENTIVE HEALTH CONSULTATIONS

Diabetes, hypertension and high cholesterol are lethal for the heart. Yet, most patients leave these conditions untreated till it is too late



POLLUTION

Ultra fine particles found in polluted air in most cities are toxic for heart health



SEDENTARY LIFESTYLE

According to a Stanford University study, Indians walk just 4,297 steps a day. For heart health, doctors recommend at least twice the count of moderate walking



SMOKING

According to Johns Hopkins, one out of every 5 smoking-related deaths is caused by heart disease. Latest data show that India ranks second globally with 250,002,133 smokers between 16 and 64 years of age



"There's little awareness of the smaller signs indicating heart problems. We don't listen to our bodies to go in for preventive check-ups"

DR NARESH TREHAN
Chairman, Medanta
- The Medicity, Gurgaon

detection and diagnosis of heart ailments has undergone a sea change, as has treatment, with a range of newer chemicals as well as surgical techniques that can handle the most extreme of cases, which once we would have given up on.

India woke up to one more grim reminder of how common sudden heart attacks have become on May 31, when singer Krishnakumar Kunnath, popularly known as KK, was rushed to the Calcutta Medical Research Institute where the doctors declared him 'brought dead'. Later, the cause of death was determined to be hypoxia, a state in which there is not enough oxygen in the blood, often triggering cardiovascular complications, including heart attacks like the one KK succumbed to. What was unusual was the fact that the singer was only 53 and had felt fit enough to perform live on a Kolkata stage only a few hours before his death. The incident recalled the tragic and untimely passing of other celebrities within a year—such as actor Sidharth Shukla on September 2 and producer Raj Kaushal two months before (see *Snatched in their Prime*).

"A young man in his 50s, with no major heart problems, dies suddenly. This has happened before," says Dr Naresh Trehan, chairman of Medanta–The Medicity hospital in Gurgaon, referring to the KK case. "Yet, there is little awareness of the smaller signs indicating heart problems. We don't listen to our bodies and go for preventive check-ups or treatment on time."

Sudden deaths such as that of KK have led to a dawning realisation that a silent heart attack can catch even the seemingly young and healthy unawares. One reason why its onset goes unnoticed is that it does not exhibit the usual symptoms associated with heart attacks, such as chest pain or shortness of breath. KK, for instance, had complained of fatigue and stomach-ache